

Introduction

Perceptions of local governments are shaped by the issues and challenges of the urban areas where people live. We look at it from particular perspectives – as property taxpayers, as service users, as community members, as scholars, as businesses, and as visitors. We use different lenses to understand it. In the course reading, Graham, Phillips, and Maslove comment that “[t]he lenses that we use to focus upon urban phenomena determine to a large degree what we see and how we explain and evaluate what we see” (1998, 19).

This module will introduce different lenses or theories for understanding local government and will challenge you to use those lenses to better understand issues in your municipality. It will also introduce some key tensions inherent in the structure of local government in Canada and in the relationship it has with community members, businesses, and other levels of government. These include the tension between efficiency and effectiveness and tensions in the role of local government, its autonomy, and who it “serves.”

Topics and Learning Objectives

Topics

- Approaches to the study of local government (understanding the main theories)
 - Institutional theory
 - Community power theories
 - Social movement theory
 - Political economy theories
 - Public choice theory
- Key tensions in local government structure and relationships
 - Efficiency versus effectiveness
 - Municipal role
 - Autonomy
 - Interest

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, you should be able to:

- Distinguish between five groups of theories of local government
- Demonstrate an understanding of theories by applying them to a local issue

- Identify key tensions that are evident in the structure and relationships of local government in Canada and the implications for local government

Readings

Reading

Please Note: You can access all non-textbook readings through the One-Stop Course Readings located in the Table of Contents in your D2L Brightspace course.

Required

1. Graham, K., Phillips, S., & Maslove, A. (1998). "Approaches to the study of urban governance." In *Urban Governance in Canada*.
 - Read pages 19–41
2. Tindal, C. R., Tindal, S. N., Stewart, K., & Smith, P. J. (2017). *Local government in Canada* (9th ed). Scarborough: Nelson.
 - Read Chapter 1 – The Promise of Local Government, pages 1 - 23.

Introduction to Theories of Local Government

"A theory provides an explanation of why things happen the way they do" (Brooks & Miljan, 2003, 22). It helps us understand why as well as predict how things will happen in the future. Theories are useful to:

- simplify and clarify our thinking about government and politics;
- identify important political forces in society;
- communicate relevant knowledge about political life;
- direct inquiry into politics; and
- suggest explanations for political events and outcomes (Brooks & Miljan, 2003, 25)

Did You Know?

The challenge with political and public policy theories is that there is no one set of theories. Scholars frequently present different sets of theories. You may see these theories with slightly different names or grouped in different buckets of theories.

For example, Graham, Phillips, and Maslove (1998) distinguish between local government theories and other theories and argue that different lenses are needed to promote understanding at the local level. In contrast, Jackson and Jackson group theories based on micro versus macro level theories; Brooks and Miljan (2003) describe two sets of theories – structuralist theories (related to the structure of politics, bureaucracy, or society) and dynamic theories (where the policy process is dynamic and open to influence).

While there is no “one” set, the theories described in this module are common to most political and public policy theories. They may be grouped somewhat differently or have slightly different names, but they provide a good foundation for thinking about local government. As you review them, please think about which contribute to your understanding of local government and urban politics and why.

Institutional Theory

Module 1 described the structure of government in Canada. The **institutional approach** focuses on how these different government institutions influence policy decisions and power relationships. For example, it is argued that the division of responsibilities in the Constitution has led to competition between provinces and territories and a resulting patchwork of policies in key areas (Brooks and Miljan, 2003). The formal assignment of responsibility for local government to provinces and territories has led to the development of certain institutions and relationships, including ministries or departments with responsibility for relationships with municipalities, and oversight and appeal bodies like the now eliminated Ontario Municipal Board. The Constitution and assignment of local government to provinces and territories has had a direct influence on the relationship between municipalities and the federal government.

The theory recognizes that institutions don't always remain the same. From the mid-1950s to the mid-1970s, the focus was on describing how local government functioned and how that functioning affected decision-making and choices. Municipalities were amalgamated and restructured to meet the needs of rapidly growing urban areas. The focus was on what went on at city hall, how municipal councils and special purpose bodies functioned, and the processes and structures through which decisions were made, as well as the relationship with the provincial government and how this affected the political choices available to local governments. This model has been criticized as being too narrowly focused on institutions, overlooking important influences from business and community interests and the external environment.

Community Power Theories

Community power theories cover a broad range of approaches to the question of who has influence at city hall.

Tab Panels (expanded):

Tab: Elite – Pluralist Theories

By the 1970s, a number of authors and critics were arguing that local governments had been captured by the development industry and that decision-making had been compromised. This was consistent with the **elite theory** approach to politics, which argued that local democracy had been subverted, and that a small group of urban elites, through their economic wealth and influence, had captured control of local government. Urban elites included large landowners, real estate developers, bankers, and heads of large corporations, who shared a common interest and perspective on economic growth and development.

In contrast, other theorists argued that power was fragmented and diffused. The **pluralists** argued that it was important to look at who actually took part in or had influence over decisions to understand government. Later pluralists identified that opportunities to participate or influence decisions was unequally distributed among individuals and groups and that some (often business interests) had more power than other interests. More recently, theorists have identified examples of **hyperpluralism**, where power is so splintered among groups that governments are weak.

Tab: Developer Dominance Theory

In the 1960s and 1970s, attention was increasingly drawn to the external influence of developers and the property industry on municipal decision-making. Local governments are responsible for planning and zoning, which determines what may be built and where – they regulate the type and density of new development. Local governments also provide the infrastructure and services to support new development, including water, roads, transit, and schools. In both situations, developers and property interests work to influence local government decisions in their favour.

Nearly every Canadian city has experience with a controversial local development. Examples include the demolition of homes or heritage sites for new development, the loss of farmland or natural habitats to new development, and pressure to build expressways through residential areas. These challenging issues inspired a new **political economy approach** to the study of local politics. James Lorimer (1978, preface) argued, “I have discovered that it is necessary to extend the investigation well beyond city hall, to the complex of business and professions (which I have labelled the property industry) involved in real estate and land development, and to examine the connections of both city hall and the property industry to the federal and provincial governments. I have, in other words, attempted to analyze city politics in its political and economic context.”

There are three implications of this approach for the study of local government. First, local governments may be biased in support of development because local governments depend on the property tax for much of their municipal revenue. Second, developers are usually large and wealthy businesses with the capacity to lobby governments and advocate for their interests.

Third, developers have powerful allies who also benefit from the new development activity to support their proposals and applications.

Tab: Growth Machine Theory

Harvey Molotch (1976, 309) took this further and concluded that development pressures on local governments were so great that city hall acted as a “growth machine,” constantly promoting new development. Molotch defined a **growth machine** as a group or coalition of property interests that argued that markets alone should determine land use. This group of property owners, called **rentiers**, tried to intensify the use of their land in an effort to maximize their profits. Typically, the growth machine was well organized, resourced, connected, and very successful at influencing politics and policy in its favour.

Tab: Regime Theory

Regime theory focuses on understanding community power and identifying how and under what conditions competing interests join together to achieve public policy goals. A regime is an informal group of public and private sector interests working together on a public policy issue. Regime theory is strongly associated with Clarence Stone’s studies of Atlanta and is based on an understanding that modern governance is complex and fragmented and no one set of players can be successful alone. It recognizes the interdependence of local government, business, the voluntary sector, and other groups. The success of a regime depends on the composition of the regime, relationships between members, resources available to it, and its institutional influence.

Social Movement Theory

There have always been interest groups in politics – individuals, organizations, or groups trying to influence government to make decisions favourable to their interests. Traditionally, many of these interest groups have come from the business community. The **social movement approach** recognizes the rise of social movements or people coming together to advocate for an issue or concern that they have in common. Examples include the environmental movement, the daycare movement, the labour movement, and the feminist movement.

Many of the groups engaged in social movements have traditionally been marginalized from the political process and have not been well represented by government. While they have a relative lack of power in society, they have been successful at organizing and obtaining results at the local level. Issues of identity and space have led to greater attention to differences, voices, and participation in local government processes.

Political Economy Theories

The **political economy approach** focuses on understanding the changing nature of economies and how urban areas/cities fit in the process of global restructuring. It recognizes that local municipalities have limited autonomy for decision-making and, as a result, there is a need to look more broadly at the structural conditions of capital accumulation, production, and consumption. Let's look at the two approaches described in the reading – the **neo-Marxist perspective** and **regulation school** – as well as the **globalization framework**.

Tab Panels (expanded):

Tab: Marxist and Neo-Marxist Theory

Marxist and **neo-Marxist theory** says that society is divided into classes, which are not equal; therefore, conflict exists among the classes. The role of the state is to mediate the classes, favouring the dominant elites to maintain the existing capitalist system. Marxists see the relationship among the classes as central to politics and decision-making. There is tension in relation to maintaining the system and responding to group conflict by providing some groups with additional services and supports.

The role of the state is to provide the general prerequisites for production and to maintain social order. The authority of the state is directly tied to economic growth and prosperity, therefore, the state focuses on creating conditions for a more efficient urban environment. Castells takes the analysis further and argues that the state is playing an increasingly active role in organizing the labour force (education, training, transportation, housing, etc.) to meet the needs of production and capital accumulation (Castells, 1977). These perspectives downplay the role and autonomy of the state and are criticized by many as being too structural and deterministic.

Tab: Regulation School Theory

The **regulation school theory** focuses on economic, social, and political developments associated with the shift, beginning in the 1970s, from a manufacturing economy. It identifies a period of relatively long-term stability where there is a balance between production, consumption, and investment. There is a regime of regulation, or a set of rules, norms, processes, networks, relationships, and ways of organizing in place that contribute to a state of balance during the period of stability. At some point, economic, demographic, or political forces act on this stability and there is a shift to a new stage, which embeds different rules, norms, and relationships.

Regulation school recognizes the role of governments in planning for and sustaining economic growth. It emphasizes macroeconomic conditions and highlights the importance of city and regional governments as they compete with other cities globally for economic development.

Tab: Globalization Theory

Globalization framework theory recognizes the influence of multinational corporations and international institutions on policy choices available to governments (Brooks and Miljan, 2003). Policies established by the United Nations, International Monetary Fund, or World Trade Organization have implications for national, regional, and local governments. At the local level, municipalities must remain competitive in the global economy to ensure their growth and development. Municipalities are influenced by a range of international structures and institutions and the tools, policy, and program choices promoted by these global institutions.

Public Choice Theory

Public choice theory defines the role of local government as the deliverer of a package of services and goods in a competitive environment. Individuals are central to this theory as they try to achieve their preferred mix (or utility maximization) of goods and services, at a price that they are willing to pay. The theory assumes that individuals will move to different jurisdictions to achieve the desired mix and cost. Local governments exist to provide the means for citizens to communicate their preferences and to respond to those preferences. City politicians similarly try to maximize their chances of re-election by responding to the majority preference.

Public choice is related to the economic concept of utility maximization – that individuals will try to get the most value or satisfaction for their money. The theory offers options for the production and provision of a public good. It criticizes local governments as inefficient because they typically act as a monopoly provider with little incentive to innovate or lower costs. The theory encourages a greater number of smaller urban municipalities, a polycentric model, to allow individual residents the greatest choice of services and prices.

This theory has been subject to strong criticism. There isn't clear evidence that lower service cost correlates with higher satisfaction; smaller, fragmented urban jurisdictions are efficient; or people are mobile in an effort to get the most value for their resources. It is less influential in local government reform in Canada than in the United States.

Reflection on the Theories

We can use theories to understand different views on an issue. There isn't one "theory" that explains an issue, but multiple perspectives that help us understand how issues are framed, argued, and decided/resolved. Theories differ in the level of analysis. As you read in the earlier overviews, theories

can focus on individuals, groups of organized individuals, classes, or broad social forces (Brooks & Miljan, 2003).

The role of the state varies in each theory. Sometimes the state is seen as reacting to interests; other times it can be proactive in pursuing its own interests (i.e., re-election and public support); and it can also be reactive to what is happening in the economy and broader society (Brooks & Miljan, 2003). These differences underscore the value in applying different theories to an issue to develop a more complete understanding of the issue.

Road Tolls in Toronto

Municipalities struggle to raise new revenues to support the provision of programs and services. From time to time, larger municipalities consider the option of imposing road tolls as a way of raising additional funds. In late 2016, Toronto City Council, after a long debate, approved the introduction of road tolls on the Don Valley Parkway (DVP) and the Gardiner Expressway. The tolls were expected to raise about \$300 million a year that would be used to fund transit in Toronto.

Let's use some of the theories to develop a better understanding of road tolls:

Looking through a regime lens

Paying for transit and road infrastructure has been a significant issue for many years in Toronto. Frustrations were running high due to the underfunding of Toronto's transit system. Many groups with very different interests were affected:

- The Board of Trade wants well-maintained and congestion-free roads so their business members can keep the local economy growing without additional property or business taxes.
- Transit riders want road toll revenue to fund more and better transit.
- Social policy advocates are concerned about transit affordability and access and welcome additional funding and service paid for through road toll revenue. As well, they don't want to give up social programs to pay for increased transit costs.
- Businesses want fewer drivers on the QEW and DVP so that they can access their clients and customers faster – they balance the toll cost with the indirect costs they pay associated with traffic congestion.
- Municipal finance officials want a wider range of revenue tools and would welcome the addition of toll revenue.

These and other groups seemed to reach some kind of informal consensus or “regime” and communicated that to municipal decision makers, who in turn voted to impose road tolls in Toronto a couple of years ago.

What other theories help explain the road tolls decision? Let's look at the issue through three more lenses:

Click-n-reveal: **Neo-Marxist**

Road tolls would result in more money to support more effective transit and transportation networks in Toronto, which would in turn support the economy and means of production.

Click-n-reveal: **Globalization**

Municipalities need to be competitive globally with effective transportation and transit networks. Road tolls are used in many global cities as a way of raising revenues – they are an accepted (although perhaps not always popular) way to raise additional revenue. Toronto would be following the example of other cities such as London and would be able to invest more significantly in transit to remain competitive internationally.

Click-n-reveal: **Public Choice**

Neighbouring municipalities, including Mississauga and Oshawa, were critical of Toronto's decision to implement road tolls and the implications it would have on their municipalities and residents. In commenting on Toronto's decision, Oshawa Mayor John Henry considered the issue through a public choice lens when he suggested, "I think this will ricochet. For the folks that would have gone to the Eaton Centre, they will stay and shop in Oshawa" (Benzie, 2017). Public choice theory suggests that residents will choose to visit Toronto and pay the road tolls or choose to take their business elsewhere. Drivers in the city will choose to use the toll roads or use other roads or transit. Some city drivers may move to other municipalities that don't have road tolls. Some employers may move to other municipalities to be able to attract workers.

You are encouraged to continue to apply the different lenses to other local government issues. As you can see, it gives you a perspective that you would not otherwise have on an issue. It also shows the complexity of issues and explains why elected members bring such different perspectives to issues and discussions – they are basing their opinion and position on different lenses on the issue. This is also why it is so hard to make decisions – a course of action that may be clear using one lens may be much less clear when one applies different lenses.

Some of you may be wondering: Why are there no road tolls on the Don Valley Parkway or the Gardiner Expressway? Shortly after the city council decision to impose road tolls, the Ontario government advised Toronto that it would overrule Toronto City Council's decision and disallow road tolls within the city (Benzie, 2017).

Introducing Four Key Tensions

While local government has evolved over the years, its foundations are in the *Baldwin Act, 1849* and in the definition of the new confederation of Canada contained in the *British North America Act, 1867*.

These foundations have led to some key tensions and challenges at the local level and in the relationship among local and other levels of government. This section introduces four tensions:

1. Efficiency vs. effectiveness
2. Municipal role
3. Autonomy
4. Interests

You will learn more about these tensions as you move through the course.

Efficiency versus Effectiveness

There is a tension between efficiency and effectiveness at the municipal level. Residents and taxpayers are always concerned with efficiency – using property taxes and municipal funding as effectively as possible, providing services at the lowest cost, and getting the most out of each municipal dollar. Increasingly, they are also concerned about effectiveness and making sure that services and programs are the best way of achieving municipal goals and results.

Key Point

Efficiency is about doing things right. It compares outputs to inputs – the higher the ratio, the more efficient an organization is. In other words, when a municipality can provide more programming or services for the same or less investment of human, financial, and time resources, it is more efficient. The Ontario Municipal Councillor's Guide (2018) calls this the stewardship role of council.

Effectiveness is about doing the right thing to achieve a goal, impact, or result.

This short video, [Efficiency vs Effectiveness, What's the Difference?](#) [1:40] explains both concepts and distinguishes between getting things done the right way versus doing the right thing.

Efficiency is part of most measures of effectiveness, but it is important to recognize that an efficient organization is not necessarily an effective one. For example, an efficient municipality can offer a service at low cost, but that service may not be the best service to achieve the municipal goal or to serve the community.

Too much attention to efficiency, often in times of resource scarcity and competing demands, can divert attention from the intended result and goal. It can also focus attention on the short term away from longer-term change-oriented programs that are hard to measure and may not compare well with other programs in terms of efficiency. Not enough focus on efficiency can result in wastage and misuse of limited resources.

Elected municipal councils must find a way to balance efficiency and effectiveness in policy and program decision-making.

Municipal Role

Tindal, Tindal, Stewart, and Smith (2019) identify the two main roles of municipal governments as:

1. Service provision
2. Democratic government

Local government was first established in the mid-1800s to provide services to properties. This service delivery role has increased significantly over the years and continues to be a key role. In fact, with government downloading of services to the local level, the municipal role in direct service delivery is greater than that of other levels of government.

Early forms of local government were quickly adapted with mechanisms to allow for some local determination of what services would be provided and at what cost. This democratic role of electing representatives has also grown over the years.

Municipal institutions in Canada date their origin to the 1837 rebellions in Lower and Upper Canada, Lord Durham's Report on the causes of the rebellions, and the action of Lord Sydenham in putting through legislation creating municipal institutions. He did this in 1841 while he was, as he called himself, "dictator." Under Sydenham's system, municipal officers were largely nominated by the Crown. This was changed in 1845 in Lower Canada, and in 1849 in Upper Canada, and an elective system was set up. These acts are the foundations of the municipal systems of Ontario and Quebec (Duncan, 1942, 427).

Local government is frequently described as closest to the people and as a theatre of strong democracy (Barber, 2013, as quoted by Hilderman, 2014). Municipalities represent their constituents and their interests through effective service delivery, but also through municipal policy and planning and by representing those interests to other levels of government. They play increasingly significant roles in key policy areas, including economic development and infrastructure, community health and development, the environment, transit, and movement and accessibility.

These roles can be in conflict. Service delivery is immediate and demands constant attention, not leaving much room for strategic, longer-term processes. Services involve delivering products, while

democratic representation is about processes and deliberation. Funding and resources are challenges for both the service and democratic roles.

In addition, both the service and democratic roles face unique challenges. The democratic role is increasingly challenged by election issues, including low voter turnout, engagement as well as issues of accountability. Service delivery must balance efficiency and effectiveness as discussed earlier.

Autonomy

Key Point

While provinces have given municipalities more power and authority over the years, “the Province remains firmly in control, limiting the legal and operational flexibility of municipalities in many ways” (Côté & Fenn, 2014, 4).

Tensions related to local government autonomy have already been introduced. Module 1 described how municipalities are the constitutional responsibility of provinces and territories; they are not a constitutionally recognized level of government in Canada. Local governments have as much authority and autonomy as provinces and territories give them in the municipal act or other legislation that establishes the duties and responsibilities of municipalities. Provinces set out areas of municipal responsibility, retain an oversight role, and can overrule decisions of elected municipalities.

The example of road tolls, in the discussion of theories and approaches earlier in this module, provided a specific example of the provincial override – the Ontario government didn’t allow the City of Toronto to introduce road tolls. In 1995, there were 850 Ontario municipalities, but by 2000, because of the Ontario government’s decision to amalgamate municipalities, this number decreased to 444 municipalities (Miljan & Spicer, 2015, 4).

In another example that is being argued in the courts, Ontario unilaterally changed the size of Toronto City Council in the middle of the 2018 municipal election. While these examples are from Ontario, other provinces have similarly shaped local government in other jurisdictions.

Whose Interests?

Whose interests do local governments serve? Most of us would answer that they serve local **residents**, **voters**, **taxpayers**, and **community members**. Although we often use the terms interchangeably, it is important to recognize these terms don’t include the same people.

- **Voters** are those eligible to vote in municipal elections. We will learn later that voters must be Canadian citizens, over 18 years old, and own property (or live) in the municipality.
- **Municipal taxpayers** are property owners – they own property and pay property tax. As discussed in Module 1, these property owners may or may not live in the municipality and they may not be

eligible to vote.

- **Community members** can be anyone who lives within the municipality – international students, recent immigrants, non-citizens, transients as well as citizens. Some of this group may not be eligible to vote. The relationship needs and interests of each of these groups are different and we need to be careful to use the right terms.

Municipalities also serve **local business**, **economic**, and **development interests** within the municipality and interests that want to locate in the municipality.

As you can see, each term has a different meaning and includes different people and interests; we will need to be careful to use the right terms.

Municipalities have a responsibility to act in the best interests of their community and its different interests. This leads to an interesting question: Should local governments make the best decisions, based on the information they have available to them, or should they represent their communities and do what their constituents want?

If they choose the latter, how do they determine what the majority of the community wants? Rarely are all residents and stakeholders in agreement about an issue, which makes it a challenge to identify and define the majority. For example, in the subway versus light rapid transit (LRT) issue, there are strong business interests in the transportation, planning, and engineering sectors who are arguing for either the LRT and the subway depending on their expertise with above- or below-ground transit. Developers and local business interests would potentially gain (or lose) based on changing land values or level of business activity, depending on the route and stops, and may prefer one mode to the other. Resident/community interests focus on getting improved accessibility to other parts of the city (and to jobs) and/or on protecting their community from development – they may either prefer the speed of the subway or the greater number of LRT stops.

If the goal is to make decisions in the best interests of the majority, doesn't this mean that underrepresented groups will continue to be marginalized? Municipalities must balance business and residential interests, as well as those of taxpaying residents and others who do not own land or pay property tax directly (renters). The discussion about the "majority" can lead to a discussion about the "common interest." Is this the same as the majority or does it include the interests of the broader society or the commonality of residents in the community?

Similarly, municipalities must balance the current needs of the current communities versus planning and working for the future community. Should they pursue a short-term project supported by the local community or a longer-term project that will have greater but longer-term benefits? Municipalities also have to decide between purely local interests and larger regional or perhaps national interests. Many environmental issues have spillover effects on other areas. Should a municipality pursue its interests without considering the impact on others or on the broader environment?

Summary

Scholars of local government and politics in Canada have often approached their subject with perspectives shaped by the issues, problems, and challenges currently facing their own cities. As Canadian municipalities developed structures of local government appropriate to the population growth

and sprawl of the post-war decades, academics concentrated on an institutional approach to studying local government. When the political influence of the development industry in local politics became apparent from the late 1960s, a number of scholars wrote about the power of the property industry in urban politics. Since social movements and interest groups began mobilizing in urban politics, many scholars have adopted more of a grassroots approach to political participation in local government.

Each of the approaches explores an important aspect of local government and city politics, but together they provide a more holistic, well-rounded understanding of how local governments function, how community members attempt to influence their municipal government, and ultimately whose interests these local institutions serve or abandon.

This is a nice segue to the module discussion on key tensions faced by local governments – efficiency versus effectiveness, as well as tensions related to role, interests, and autonomy. You will see frequent connections to these issues in the course modules that follow.

Key Takeaways

- The module described five sets of theories that help us understand local government:
 - Institutional theory focuses on the role that institutions, including structures, processes, and rules, play in shaping issues and decisions.
 - Community power theories look at who has power. It identifies elites, developers, property interests, and other groups of interests, and how they influence and shape local issues.
 - Social movement theory focuses on groups or movements of people advocating for issues or shared concerns and the influence they bring to local issues.
 - Political economy theories consider the influence of the changing economy on local government and its efforts to support continued economic growth, prosperity, and competitiveness.
 - Public choice theory focuses attention on the individual as a consumer and their desire to get a set of local government services for a price they are willing to pay, which leads to fragmentation and competition between municipalities over services and price.
- Considering issues or decisions through multiple theories will provide a more complete understanding of the complexity of the issue.
- The module also introduced four tensions or themes that you will revisit as you move through the course:
 - Tension between efficiency and effectiveness
 - Tension between the municipal service delivery and democratic roles
 - Tensions about municipal autonomy and the relationship with provinces and territories
 - Tensions related to interests and how local governments balance the many interests they serve

Coming Up Next

Module 3 will provide an overview of the development of local government in Canada from the early days to the present. It will consider the forces and pressures that have shaped the local government we have in place today, including growth, suburbanization, new public management, and more. It is important to have an appreciation of the development of local government role, structures, and processes to understand the current form as well as current forces for change.

Discussions and Assignments

Week 2 Discussion

Let's look at a current municipal issue through the different lens (theories) that are discussed in Module 2. I would like you to think about a recent issue, whether to permit cannabis shops, the subway versus LRT debate, or another issue. If you are not from Toronto, you are welcome to use a topical issue or project (like community centre, casino, gas plant, etc.) in or near your municipality.

Think about the frameworks – institutional, community power, social movement, political economy, and public choice – and apply them to your analysis of the issue. Which theories help you understand the broad and complex issue? Why? What insights do they provide on the policy question? While there may be one theory that stands out regarding an issue, the issues can be looked at from different perspectives, and different theories can apply. Please consider other lenses through which you can understand the issue.

Please don't get into a discussion of the content or issue, i.e., whether subways are better than LRTs. Instead, discuss how the theories help you understand the broader issue.

Required

- Please complete this discussion activity by 11:59 p.m. on Friday of this module week.
- Please see the Week 2 discussion topic in your D2L course for further instructions.

Note: You will be asked to self-assess your participation in the Weeks 1, 2, and 3 course discussions at the end of Week 3 – this self-assessment will contribute to your self-assessed participation grade.

See the Assessment and Evaluation section of this Course Outline for details.

Note: You can access the Discussion Forums & Topics section from the Communications menu in your D2L course.

Please make sure that your participation in all discussion forums adheres to the Toronto Metropolitan University online etiquette guidelines listed in the Course Outline.

Assignment

- There is no assignment due this week.

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